

RMD Birmingham: **Result Release Support** **Information for Student** **Faculty**



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Contact telephone number for Security Services **0121 414 4444** for emergencies, first aid etc.

(0121 414 3000 can be used for non-emergencies)

Guidance for communicating student assessment failure

Principles to be considered when providing results release to students:

- Be...Clear and accurate
 - Be explicit about the outcome (e.g., fail, referral, resit required).
 - Avoid vague language that could lead to misunderstanding.
 - Ensure alignment with regulations.

- Be...Compassionate and respectful
 - Recognise that failure can be emotionally challenging.
 - Use a calm, non-judgmental tone.
 - Avoid language that assigns blame.
 - Allow space for questions.

- Be...Developmental and supportive
 - Focus not only on what went wrong, but how to improve.
 - Provide actionable, specific feedback.

- Be...Consistent with institutional values and student wellbeing priorities
 - Apply the same standards and messaging across students.
 - Follow relevant institutional policy
 - Use institutional guidance and signposting resources

Delivering the Message

Core Skills

Emotional Regulation (Yourself)

Before managing the student, manage your own response:

- Stay calm and steady in tone
- Avoid reacting defensively or personally
- Be comfortable with pauses and silence

If emotions escalate, slow the pace of the conversation rather than trying to “fix” it quickly.

Active Listening

Demonstrate that you are taking the student seriously:

- Maintain eye contact (if appropriate)
- Use minimal encouragers (“I see”, “Go on”)
- Reflect key points

Example:

“It sounds like you were expecting a different outcome and this has come as a shock.”

Validation (Without Agreeing)

Acknowledge the student’s feelings without changing the academic decision.

Example:

“I can understand why this feels frustrating.”

“It’s completely understandable to feel disappointed.”

Setting

Provide a private, quiet setting (whether face-to-face or online)

Ensure adequate time (avoid rushed conversations)

Managing Student Reactions

Failure can trigger a range of emotional, cognitive, and behavioural reactions, including:

- Shock or disbelief
- Distress or anxiety
- Anger or defensiveness
- Shame or withdrawal
- Bargaining

These reactions are normal and often linked to identity, confidence, and future concerns—not just the assessment itself.

Suggestions for responding to specific reactions

Reaction	Signs	Approach	Example phrases	Practical strategy
Distress or Emotional Upset	Crying, visible anxiety, overwhelmed Difficulty processing information	• Pause the academic discussion briefly • Acknowledge emotion • Offer space and reassurance	<i>"I can see this is really difficult—let's take a moment."</i> <i>"We don't have to go through everything right now if that's too much."</i>	• Break information into smaller chunks • Offer a follow-up meeting • Gently signpost support services
Anger or Confrontation	Raised voice, blaming tone, challenging fairness	• Stay calm and do not match tone • Do not take comments personally • Refocus on evidence and process	<i>"I can hear that you're frustrated."</i> <i>"Let's look at how the marking criteria were applied."</i> <i>"I want to help, but we need to keep this conversation respectful."</i>	• Use neutral language • Avoid arguing or "winning" • Offer formal routes (appeals, review processes)
Silence or Withdrawal	Minimal responses, lack of engagement, shutdown	• Allow silence (don't rush to fill it) • Use open but gentle prompts • Offer alternative ways to engage	<i>"I realise this is a lot to take in—what's going through your mind?"</i> <i>"Would you prefer to follow up by email or another meeting?"</i>	• Agree follow up that works best for student

Reaction	Signs	Approach	Example phrases	Practical strategy
Denial or Disagreement	Rejecting feedback, disputing grade, focusing on effort rather than criteria	• Acknowledge perspective • Anchor discussion in clear criteria and evidence • Explain formal review processes if needed	"If you'd like, I can explain the formal process for reviewing a mark."	• Offer formal routes (appeals, review processes)
Bargaining	Requests to change mark informally Appeals to sympathy	• Be firm but respectful • Reinforce fairness and consistency	<i>"I'm not able to change marks, what I can do is help you maximise your performance in the resit."</i>	• Set boundaries and expectations clearly • Offer formal routes (appeals, review processes)

When emotions arise, use this simple model:

Acknowledge → Stabilise → Refocus → Support

Acknowledge: - *“I can see this is upsetting.”*

Stabilise: - *“Let’s take a moment.”*

Refocus: - *“Shall we look at what will help you move forward?”*

Support: - *“Here are the next steps and support available to you.”*

De-escalation Techniques

- Lower your voice and slow your speech
- Use the student’s name (appropriately) to personalise
- Avoid interrupting
- Focus on future actions rather than past failure

When to Pause or End the Conversation

It is appropriate to pause if:

- The student is too distressed to engage
- The discussion becomes unproductive or confrontational

Example:

“It might be helpful to pause here and arrange another time to continue this conversation.”

Signposting During Emotional Reactions

Introduce support naturally, not as an afterthought:

“Many students find it helpful to speak with support services after getting difficult results—would you like information on that?”

Avoid making this feel like dismissal:

ý *“You should go and talk to counselling”*

p *“There are people who can support you through this”*

Aftercare: Academic Follow-Up

Suggestions on how to follow up:

- A summary email after the conversation
- Clear written next steps
- Invitation to follow up

“I’m happy to meet again after you’ve had time to review the feedback.”

Expectations - Key Reminder for Staff

You are not expected to:

- Resolve all emotional responses
- Act as a counsellor

Your role is to:

- Communicate clearly
- Respond humanely
- Direct students toward appropriate support
- Maintain academic integrity

Signposting Support

Encourage students to access:

- Academic skills support
- Personal tutoring
- Wellbeing or counselling services
- Disability or learning support services (if relevant)

Common Pitfalls to Avoid

- Delivering feedback only as criticism without guidance
- Overloading students with too much feedback at once
- Being ambiguous about the outcome
- Minimising student’s emotional response
- Providing inconsistent advice